expect us to be on the same debate as some junior spokesperson of the BJP,' Sharma said, somewhat dismissively. Even Manish Tewari, who was once their main pugilist on television, was now an information and broadcasting minister. 'I am now part of the government, so I can't speak freely on every issue,' was his explanation.

It was a familiar excuse. The UPA government wasn't short of effective speakers. Individuals like Chidambaram, Kapil Sibal, Jyotiraditya Scindia and Sachin Pilot would have made a formidable communication team. But they shunned the media like wounded lions, with barely concealed rage, believing that 24/7 news was responsible for most of the UPA's misfortunes. Till 2010, Chidambaram, easily the government's most cerebral politician, would even offer to come to the studio. Now, neither he nor any potentially credible voice was ready to get into the hurly-burly of 'noise' television. It almost seemed as if the cacophony over the Anna agitation and the string of scams had forced the government's key interlocutors to surrender a crucial public space. In 2009, many of them had led the Congress charge; now they had gone missing in action. Their silence only added to the cloud of doom and gloom hanging over the party.

By contrast, the BJP had packed its ranks with Smriti Irani, Piyush Goyal, Ravi Shankar Prasad, Nirmala Sitharaman, Meenakshi Lekhi, even Arun Jaitley, each a doughty fighter for the cause. The party was well prepared for the war on television. As an Opposition party, it was perhaps a shade easier to be aggressive. The BJP had a standard operating media drill in place for the election. Every morning at around 10.30, there would be a tele-conference of all the BJP spokespersons to decide the official stance on an issue. By 3 p.m., the party would have decided which spokesperson would be assigned to which news channel.

Under Maken's watch, the Congress belatedly attempted a similar media plan, only their cupboard appeared bare in contrast. Unlike the BJP, many senior Congress spokespersons were contesting the elections and were not available in Delhi. In desperation, the Congress rehabilitated Dr Abhishek Singhvi, its long-serving lawyer-spokesperson. Singhvi had been out in the cold for over a year after being caught on tape in a sex CD. The party also